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PRACTICAL FIELD GUIDE / 2026

AI Tools by Domain

A practical directory for assistants, coding, research, study, automation, and visual work.

How to read this guide. This is a broad practical list, not every product on the market. Free usually means a limited free tier; subscription means paid plans or usage charges. Prices and availability can vary by country and change over time.

Licensing key. Open source means the software code is published under an open license. **Proprietary** means the provider controls the software or model, even if it offers free access. **Open weight** means model weights are downloadable; check the model license separately.

01 General AI assistants and GPT models

General-purpose assistants can help across writing, research, analysis, and planning. Model availability depends on the product and plan.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
ChatGPT Plans	General questions, writing, research, document and data analysis, and brainstorming.	Proprietary; free tier and paid plans. API use is billed separately.
Claude Plans	Long documents, writing, analysis, and coding.	Proprietary; free tier and paid plans.
Gemini Plans	General assistance, Google apps, multimodal work, and research.	Proprietary; free access and paid Google AI plans.
Perplexity Plans	Web research with linked sources.	Proprietary; free tier and paid plans.
GPT-6 Astra, GPT-6 Sol, and GPT-6 Luna ChatGPT plans Model catalog	Astra for hardest end-to-end work, Sol for coding and agent workflows, and Luna for faster high-volume tasks, as listed in the supplied guide.	Proprietary; ChatGPT access depends on plan and API use is separately billed.
gpt-oss-20b and gpt-oss-120b Details	Downloadable open-weight language models for local or hosted use.	Apache 2.0 model license; free download. Hardware or paid hosting may cost extra.

Note. The open-weight gpt-oss models are separate from ChatGPT and the OpenAI API. Check hardware requirements before choosing local use.

02 Coding

Choose an editor assistant, a coding agent, or a local workflow. Open-source coding tools may still incur model or hosting charges.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
GitHub Copilot Plans	Code completion, chat, and coding agents in popular editors.	Proprietary; free tier and paid plans.
Cursor Pricing	AI-assisted editing and agents that work across a codebase.	Proprietary; free Hobby tier with limits and paid plans.

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TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
OpenAI Codex Plans	Assigning coding tasks to an agent from the app, IDE, or terminal.	Proprietary; access depends on eligible ChatGPT plans and usage limits.
Claude Code Plans	Terminal-based coding agent and multi-file changes.	Proprietary; paid Claude plans or API usage.
Gemini Code Assist Product	Coding help in supported development environments.	Proprietary; individual access is free, with paid options for higher or business use.
Windsurf / Devin Desktop Current plans	AI-assisted coding and agent workflows. Windsurf now redirects to Devin Desktop.	Proprietary; free and paid plans. Check the current page for details.
Continue License	Open-source coding assistant for IDEs; connect a model of your choice.	Apache 2.0 software; free. Hosted model or API use may cost extra.
Aider License	Terminal-based AI pair programming and multi-file changes.	Apache 2.0 software; free. Model API or hosting may cost extra.
Ollama License	Running supported language models locally.	MIT-licensed model runner; free. Downloaded models have separate licenses and hardware needs.

Note. For a local setup, Ollama can run compatible models, while Continue or Aider provides a coding workflow. Model licenses and hardware requirements still matter.

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03 Building apps and projects

Prompt-driven builders can create a first app quickly; review generated code, permissions, and deployment settings before launch.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
Lovable Pricing	Creating web apps from natural-language descriptions.	Proprietary; free credits and paid plans.
Bolt.new Pricing	Building and previewing web apps in a browser.	Proprietary; free tier and paid plans.
Replit Agent Pricing	Building, editing, and deploying apps in one hosted workspace.	Proprietary; limited free use and paid plans.
v0 Pricing	Generating interfaces and web app code, especially front ends.	Proprietary; free credits and paid plans.
Dify License	Building AI apps, agents, and document-based chatbots.	Self-hosted code has an Apache 2.0-based license with extra conditions; cloud plans are paid.

04 System and workflow automation

Automation tools connect apps and trigger repeatable workflows. Check what an agent can read, change, or send before enabling it.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
n8n License	Connecting apps and automating workflows, including AI steps.	Free self-hosted Community Edition; cloud plans paid. Source-available under a restricted Sustainable Use License, not standard open source.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
Make Pricing	Visual, no-code automations across apps.	Proprietary; free tier and paid plans.
Zapier Pricing	Connecting apps through triggers and actions.	Proprietary; free tier and paid plans.
Microsoft Power Automate Plans	Microsoft workflows and desktop automation.	Proprietary; some free capabilities, with paid plans for more features.
OpenClaw Project and license	A personal assistant that runs on your computer and connects to messaging apps.	MIT open source; free software. Model, hosting, or hardware costs may apply.

Note. n8n is source-available but its Sustainable Use License restricts some commercial use. Make and Zapier offer free tiers with paid upgrades.

05 Research, literature discovery, and data analysis

Research assistants can speed up discovery and reading. Treat generated citations and summaries as leads, then verify them against the original paper.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
Elicit Pricing	Finding papers, extracting evidence, and supporting literature reviews.	Proprietary; free tier and paid plans.
Consensus Plans	Questions answered from research papers.	Proprietary; free tier and paid plans.
SciSpace Pricing	Searching papers and asking questions about PDFs.	Proprietary; free tier and paid plans.
Scite Pricing	Checking how later papers cite a study, including supporting or contrasting citations.	Proprietary; limited free access and paid plans.
ResearchRabbit About plans	Exploring related papers, authors, and citation networks.	Proprietary service; core tool free, with optional premium offerings.
NotebookLM Google AI plans	Asking questions about uploaded papers, notes, and sources.	Proprietary; free access with higher limits on paid Google AI plans.
Julius Pricing	Analyzing spreadsheets and data, statistics, charts, and reports.	Proprietary; free usage with limits plus paid subscriptions.
Anara AI Pricing	Researching papers, asking questions about uploaded documents, and organizing citations.	Proprietary; limited free plan plus paid subscriptions.
Bohrium Research tools	Scientific-paper search, paper chat, literature-review drafts, deep research, and research figures.	Proprietary; free access and paid upgrades.

Note. For evidence searches, Elicit, Consensus, and Scite have free and paid options. ResearchRabbit says its core tool is free.

06 Research paper drafting and Overleaf

Use writing assistants for structure and language, but verify every claim, citation, and journal requirement yourself.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
Overleaf Plans	Writing papers in LaTeX and collaborating with co-authors.	Hosted service; free and paid plans. AI features and limits depend on the plan.

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TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
Writefull Overleaf integration	Academic language editing and suggestions, including Overleaf integration.	Proprietary; free basic use and paid features.
Paperpal Plans	Academic editing, paraphrasing, and manuscript checks.	Proprietary; limited free use and paid subscriptions.
Zotero Support	Saving sources and managing citations and bibliographies.	Free and open source; a reference manager rather than an AI writer.

Note. Follow your institution's and journal's rules for AI use. Keep source PDFs and check references against original publications.

07 Resume and CV building

Resume builders help with layout and tailoring. Check every generated claim for accuracy before sending an application.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
FlowCV Pricing	Creating a clean CV and exporting a PDF.	Proprietary; free plan supports one resume; AI features and extra versions are paid.
Rezi Pricing	Resume drafting and tailoring to job descriptions.	Proprietary; free limited plan and paid plans.
Teal Pricing	Resume editing and tracking job applications.	Proprietary; free core tools and paid Teal+ features.
Overleaf CV templates Overleaf plans	Making a LaTeX CV with detailed formatting control.	Overleaf has a free plan; templates are not AI resume builders.

Note. FlowCV's free plan includes one resume and PDF downloads; Rezi and Teal also offer free options with paid upgrades.

08 Academic study and problem solving

Tutors and study tools work best when they explain reasoning and help you practice, rather than simply supplying a final answer.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
Khanmigo Plans	Tutor-style guidance that leads students through a problem.	Proprietary; learner and parent plans are paid and region-limited. Some teacher tools are free in eligible regions.
Wolfram Alpha Pro	Math, science, and calculation questions.	Proprietary; free basic use and paid Pro subscription.
Quizlet AI study tools Upgrade	Flashcards, study guides, practice tests, and summaries.	Proprietary; free features, with some advanced tools requiring Quizlet Plus.
StudyFetch Study tools	Turning PDFs, slides, notes, and lectures into flashcards, quizzes, summaries, and study plans.	Proprietary; free to try, with paid plans for more usage and larger files.
NotebookLM Google AI plans	Studying from your own lecture notes and readings.	Proprietary; free access with higher limits on paid plans.
ChatGPT or Gemini Gemini ChatGPT plans	Explaining concepts, generating practice questions, and reviewing your reasoning.	Proprietary; free tiers and paid plans. Verify calculations and factual answers.

Note. Khanmigo's learner and parent plans have regional availability limits. Check the official page for your location.

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09 Copilots for office work and project management

These tools work inside document, email, and task-management systems. Access and AI limits often depend on the organization's existing plan.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
Microsoft 365 Copilot Plans	Copilot features in Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams.	Proprietary; access depends on your Microsoft subscription or license.
Gemini for Google Workspace Workspace plans	AI help in Docs, Gmail, Sheets, Slides, and other Google apps.	Proprietary; availability and limits depend on your Workspace plan.
Notion AI Plans	Finding and working with notes, documents, and project plans.	Proprietary; limited free trial responses, with more AI features on paid plans.
ClickUp Brain Pricing	AI help with task plans, docs, and project workflows.	Proprietary; limited AI access or trials, with paid plans and add-ons.
Linear Pricing	Software project planning and AI-assisted issue workflows.	Proprietary; free and paid plans; AI features depend on the plan.

10 Presentations and visual work

Presentation and design tools can turn outlines into a first draft. Review facts, image rights, and layout before sharing.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
Gamma Pricing	Generating and editing presentations, documents, and web pages.	Proprietary; free tier with limited AI credits and paid plans.
Canva Pricing	Slides, posters, diagrams, and visual CVs.	Proprietary; free tier and paid Pro or Business plans.

11 Image generation and editing

Image generation is useful for illustrations, mockups, and visual assets. For diagrams with exact labels, use a diagram tool or a rendered text-based format.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
Gemini image generation Google AI plans	Generating and editing images; can also help create infographics and visual explanations.	Proprietary; limited free access, with higher limits on paid Google AI plans.
ChatGPT Images ChatGPT plans	Creating and editing images from prompts; GPT models can plan a graphic or write diagram code.	Proprietary; available across ChatGPT plans with limits that vary by plan.
Adobe Firefly Plans	Images, image edits, and vector graphics.	Proprietary; limited free generations plus subscriptions.
Ideogram Pricing Model licensing	Posters, graphics, and images where readable text matters.	Proprietary web service; free credits plus paid plans. Some model weights have a separate research and non-commercial license.
ComfyUI Project and license	Building local, node-based image-generation workflows.	Open-source software, available free. Image models you add have separate licenses, which vary.

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Note. For local image generation, ComfyUI is the workflow interface; model weights are separate downloads with separate usage terms.

12 Diagrams, flowcharts, and scientific figures

Use these to convert a process or outline into an editable diagram. Check generated labels and arrow directions before relying on the result.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	LICENSE AND COST
Napkin AI Pricing	Turning text into flowcharts, mind maps, infographics, and other visuals.	Proprietary; free plan with limited credits plus paid subscriptions.
Miro AI Pricing	Flowcharts, process maps, and team whiteboards.	Proprietary; free plan with limits plus paid subscriptions.
Whimsical AI Pricing	Flowcharts, mind maps, and quick concept diagrams.	Proprietary; free plan with limits plus paid subscriptions.
Eraser Plans	Software architecture, database, and system diagrams.	Proprietary; limited free plan plus paid plans.
Mermaid + ChatGPT or Gemini Mermaid ChatGPT Gemini	Creating editable flowcharts and technical diagrams from text instructions.	Mermaid is open source and free. Ask a GPT or Gemini model to write the diagram text, then render it with Mermaid.
Bohrium SciDraw Research tools	Scientific and research figures from ideas, paper content, or academic writing.	Part of proprietary Bohrium; free access and paid upgrades.

Note. Quick picks: Napkin for text-to-visuals; Mermaid plus GPT or Gemini for editable technical flowcharts; Eraser for software architecture; Bohrium SciDraw for research figures.

A low-cost starter set

For general work, start with ChatGPT or Gemini. For coding, try Copilot Free or open-source Continue and Aider. For automation, compare Make and self-hosted n8n. For research papers, pair NotebookLM, Zotero, and Overleaf. For a CV, try FlowCV.

For academic work, verify claims and citations against original sources and follow your institution's or journal's AI-use rules. Product names, licenses, plan limits, and availability can change; use the linked official pages for current details.

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